Design Review
Types of Planning Permits
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Design Review FAQ

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Design Review

About

To ensure new construction and remodeling in Piedmont is attractive, safe, and harmonious with its surroundings, the City engages in a design review process. The intent of the process is to preserve Piedmont's architectural heritage, aesthetic values, design character and natural beauty.

Design review is the process for making sure your project meets the City's planning and design standards. Many projects need design review before you can get a building permit.

Types

There are several types of design review permits:

- Director (DRD)
- Expedited (DREX)
- Planning Commission (DRPC)
- Planning Commission Multifamily Development (DRPC)
- Fence, wall, or site feature (DRFW)
- Variance (VAR)
- Sign (SIGN)
- Conditional use (CUP)
- Public facility

Standards

For a design review permit to be approved, the design of a project must conform to all 3 of the standards in City Code section 17.66.060:

1. The proposed design is consistent with the City's General Plan and Piedmont Design Guidelines.
2. The Design has little or no effect on neighboring properties' existing views, privacy, and access to direct and indirect light.
3. The Proposed design does not adversely affect pedestrian or vehicular safety.

Exemptions

Many small improvements do not require a design review permit, such as:

- Normal repairs and maintenance, as long as there's not change in materials, design, and size
- Interior remodeling, if the use and number of rooms allowed to be bedrooms don't change
- Fence, if it's 6 feet or less including any retaining wall, and not located in a front set back (if there is a retaining wall it needs to be less than 30 inches in height)

Review the full list of projects exempt from design review.

Requirements

When you apply online, you will need to upload documents based on the application type. If the applicant is not the Property Owner, please include the agent and permit authorization form for all planning permits. Review these resources to learn about the documents you'll need to prepare:

Director
Expedited
Planning Commission
Fence, wall, or site feature

Fence, wall, or site feature

This permit is reviewed by the Planning Commission and is required for any project that proposes a fence, retaining wall taller than 30 inches, wall, gate, site features (such as arbor, air conditioning units, heat pumps, hot tubs, or benches) in the 20-foot street yard setback. It is also required for projects that propose site features greater than 7 feet in the side or rear setback.

If an Applicant needs a list of required neighbors to notify, please contact planning staff.

- Submittal deadlines, guidelines and checklist
- Story Pole guidelines
- Story Pole certification form
- Stormwater requirements checklist
- Reach Code compliance information
- Notice by Applicant package
- Design Review findings

Sign
Conditional Use
Variance
Public facility

Approval expiration and extensions

After you get design review approval, you can get building permits. They need to be issued within 1 year of the design review approval. If you are not able to make that deadline, you can request an extension. If you don't get an extension, you need to apply for design review again.

Resources

- Chapter 17 of the City Code (the zoning ordinance)
- Piedmont Design Guidelines
- Construction Cost Estimate
- Heat Pump Requirements
- Design review frequently asked questions
- Residential Parking and Driveway Policy
- Site Visit Policy
- Story Pole Policy
- Tankless Water Heater Policy
- Window Replacement Policy

- Building Height Calculation Example
- Corner Obstructions - Regulations
- Graphic Calculations Example - Structure Coverage, Hardscape Surface Coverage, and Floor Area Ratio

How to apply

The City of Piedmont has a new online permitting system called eTRAKiT. You can now apply for and track your design review planning permit online. Paper and email applications for planning permits are no longer accepted.

Before you apply, we recommend you contact us to discuss your application. This will often lead to a faster turnaround time.

APPLY FOR A DESIGN REVIEW PLANNING PERMIT

Get help

- Call (510) 420-3050
- Email OnDutyPlanner@Piedmont.ca.gov

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